

impressed with the descriptions of how power is manipulated in the process of negotiating for, planning, staging, and managing media coverage of elections debates. The political scientist should find that elements of rhetorical analysis are useful in evaluating the past effects of debates and understanding the techniques that campaign operatives prefer in contemporary debates. Anyone interested in political debates should be stimulated to examine questions that are raised by past presidential debate practice.

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Benoit, William L., Blaney, Joseph R., & Pier, P. M. *Campaign '96: A Functional Analysis of Acclaiming, Attacking, and Defending*. Westport, CT: Praeger, 1998. \$62.95 hardcover. ISBN: 0-275-96361-6. 264 pages.

This entry in the Praeger Series in Political Communication attempts to establish “a functional theory of political campaign communication, arguing that such discourse can be understood as acclaiming, attacking, and defending on topics of policy and character” (p. xvii). While I will ultimately claim that the authors’ case requires further refinement to constitute a workable theory, the book provides substantial exposition of problems with current political campaign discourse research and points scholars in potentially productive directions for solutions to these problems. Despite some shortcomings, the book is sufficiently strong to be of interest to political communication and argumentation scholars in search of a supplementary or reserve textbook for classes emphasizing an empirical approach to campaign discourse analysis using a case study recent enough to be familiar to a broad age range of students. Debate scholars interested in political communication may also find the book an interesting analysis of the use of real-world argumentation that closely follows academic debate notions of argument construction, attack, and defense.

Noting that politics necessarily requires a choice between candidates, the authors assert a functional approach to categorizing campaign discourse into one of three categories: *acclaiming*, or self-praise; *attacking*, or criticism of one’s opponent; and *defending*, or response to criticism from opponents (p. xi). Further, the authors separate messages into those speaking to *policies* and those speaking to *character*. Benoit, et al., claim superiority

for their approach over past literature in that their model recognizes defense messages while others concentrate on acclamation and attack, and that their study recognizes different levels of character and issue claims than traditional literature which concentrates solely on an “issues versus image” dichotomy which is often blurred. The authors also avow unique strengths to their approach in recognizing that there may be a variety of types of utterances within a single campaign message, that there may be several different targets for each message, and that their study includes analysis of campaign discourse beyond concentration solely on political advertising (p. 19-22). The remainder of the book is essentially an empirical case study of the 1996 presidential campaign analyzing the discourse by placing it within these three categories.

Part I of the book is an overview section laying out the principles of the theory, providing justificatory arguments for the categories and the use of the 1996 presidential campaign as a case study, and describing the procedures for data collection and coding. Part II concentrates on data collected from the Republican primaries through analysis of candidate debates, television advertisements, and talk radio. Part III shifts analysis to the party nominating conventions and the keynote speeches, acceptance addresses, and speeches made by candidates’ spouses. Part IV is an analysis of the general election campaign through television advertisements, radio addresses, the presidential debates, and use of free television. Finally, Part V notes outcomes and suggests implications of the research.

The book has several strengths which justify interest. Chapter 1 contains acknowledgments of audience diversity and the need for presidential candidates to concentrate messages on state and regional demographics rather than simple national opinion polls. The 2000 election certainly demonstrates the merit of that position. The extensive collection of a variety of political campaign messages provides a rich data set which scholars of political communication may find more exciting than the traditional emphasis on television ads. A literature review and analysis accompanying each section is a far more effective tool for helping the reader understand the new ground the authors are trying to break in comparison with previous literature than it would be if all of the literature were reviewed independently in a beginning chapter. In the concluding chapter, the authors seem to be aware that the book is a starting point for future research, and that the theory they assert needs further refinement.

Weaknesses in the book’s content and analysis, in my view, suggest that while the study is indeed a good starting point, there is substantial work to be done to justify the

proclamation of a new theory of political campaign discourse analysis. The initial problem for the authors is their choice of the 1996 presidential campaign as the focus of their study, a problem they seem to recognize as early as the preface (xiv-xvi). In fact, the rationale for using the campaign strikes me as suspiciously defensive, citing polls from well before most of the campaign messages the study analyzes, relying on exit polls that last year's election should now have us convinced are less than perfect, and even making non-sequitur comparisons to former President Bush's popularity levels during Operation Desert Storm. The authors are adamant in their claim, even in this election which many considered not very close, that political communication literature clearly demonstrates that discourse affects voting. However, every citation the authors use to support this position deals with political advertising or presidential debates, despite the fact that they claim that focusing on traditional analyses of ads and debates is a shortcoming of previous research. Even the defense of the selected case made in the preface ignores what I think are crucial questions of whether the 1996 campaign was typical, unique, or even very interesting. One might wonder whether the theory would hold in a campaign where incumbency was not an issue, where a third party candidacy made an impact (as it apparently did in 2000), or where control of Congress was or was not at stake. Of course, the authors of a 1998 book could not predict the historic election of 2000, but precedents such as George Wallace's capturing of several states in 1968, Perot's 18% of the popular vote in 1992, the dramatic shift from Democrats to Republicans in the House of Representatives, and the chance to contrast Clinton's run for a second term with that of his predecessor would have pointed the authors in this direction.

A second weakness of the book lies in its lack of clarity in describing several of the categories used to classify political messages. While the authors claim that including defense as a message type advances the study of campaign argumentation, it is unclear what exactly they mean by "defense." They credit Jamieson for examining "inoculation strategies" (p. 32), but concentrate their research solely on reactive defense messages (those in direct response to a criticism from the opponent). To what degree do preemptive messages serve as "defense"? And how is defense necessarily different from "acclaiming"? The authors identify two general types of acclaiming messages: those which enhance the candidate's desirability, and those which enhance credit given to the candidate. But wouldn't some defensive messages achieve the same effects? Evidence of the weakness of defense as a separate category is most strongly suggested by the results of the study itself.

Defense messages made up *less than 1%* of all political campaign discourse in the 1996 presidential campaign aside from the presidential debates themselves (p. 32). Even the Chapter 12 analysis of the Clinton/Dole debates shows President Clinton with only 11% defensive messages (not a remarkable number for an incumbent), and Dole with 4%. Ultimately, I contend that the authors fail to justify use of “defense” as a theoretical category of remarkable significance.

The problems with categories continue when the authors attempt to divide messages into those of “policy” and those of “character.” While criticizing previous literature for blurring “issue” and “image,” the authors of this study do little more than that with their own terminology. They plainly admit that the two are often “inexorably intertwined” (p. 23-24). In Chapter 2, the authors construct a chart dividing policy issues into those of “past deeds,” “future plans,” and “general goals.” Character issues are “personal qualities,” “leadership ability,” and “ideals, principles, and values” (p. 25). These delineations are hardly helpful. Are messages about Clinton’s “draft dodger” reputation a “character” issue focusing on “leadership ability” as commander-in-chief? Do they focus on personal foibles such as skirting responsibility? Or was Clinton’s avoidance of military service a “past deed” making his credibility with the military a policy issue? The authors present no clear rationale for placing such messages in a given category.

The earlier mentioned assertion of how campaign discourse affects the outcome of the election is also a problem for this study. In Chapter 3, the authors discuss the time candidates devote to issues of importance to voters as projected by opinion polls. Even if the polls are assumed to be reflective of how voters actually vote (as opposed to how they say they will vote), the authors have an unanswered “chicken-egg” dilemma: to what extent, if any, does the campaign discourse alter the answers to the polls? How does discourse evolve during the campaign? The authors note the different types of audiences relevant at given times (reinforcement of loyalists during the convention, reaching for the undecided vote as the election draws near), and they acknowledge effects such as “convention bounce,” but by using general polling data on voting compared to general polling data on which issues most concerned voters, they seem to obviate that which they recognize.

Finally, and perhaps most importantly, the results of the study in the book do not seem to bear out significant portions of the authors’ theory. I have already noted that the “defense” category does not seem sufficiently significant as to warrant creating a unique spot in the theoretical construct. The chapters of the book which provide results of the data

analysis repeatedly emphasize this point. Defense occurs only 9% of the time in the GOP primary debates, 2% in GOP primary television ads, 6% in talk radio during the primary, and not at all in the convention keynote speeches. Dole found himself “defending” more often than other GOP primary candidates. Since Dole was the front-runner for the nomination, one hardly is surprised at this result. Defense messages occur less than 1% of the time in acceptance speeches and are entirely absent in spouses’ speeches. General campaign television ads find defense messages less than 1% of the time, and less than 2% on radio addresses. With less than 1% occurring on free television, only the aforementioned 11% for Clinton and 4% for Dole during the presidential debates themselves seem even noticeable. At the end of reading the results of this study, one is left to wonder what we have learned from the “defense” category that we would not have learned from the traditional categories of “acclaiming” and “attacking.”

The results of the “policy” versus “character” dichotomy seem to shed little light on the analysis of campaign discourse. Dole attacked Clinton’s character more than Clinton attacked Dole. Given that sexual and financial scandals had dogged President Clinton since the 1992 primary campaign, this again seems to be a result one would not have to collect much data to anticipate. Chapter 12 reports analysis of Clinton defenses of his character which rely on policy issues, adding fuel to the argument that the lines are so blurred as to be essentially meaningless (p. 180).

In conclusion, Benoit, Blaney, and Pier may have raised more questions than they have answered in their attempt to create theory. This in itself is not a bad thing; perhaps it is through this beginning that a theory may ultimately be articulated more clearly. Until then, the authors of this book and other scholars may want to approach questions such as whether defense messages are an important category for campaign discourse. If so, are there differences in inoculation messages and reactive defenses? Is there a bright line between messages dealing with policies and those pertaining to character? How do campaign messages evolve as the campaign evolves; do the categories change? How so? To what extent do the utterances affect the perceptions of the audience? Do the utterances change how people feel about the relative importance of issues, or do they merely link a candidate with issues the polls show people care about? Does the use of categories such as “acclaiming,” “attacking,” and “defending” have meaning only to the political scientist or communication scholar? Communication scholars are fond of asserting that “meaning lies in the mind of the receiver” of the message. This book does not address the issue of whether

the *target audiences* see a particular message as fitting the same category as do the coders for the study. Finally, will the results for the 1996 presidential campaign hold up for other presidential campaigns? If this is, indeed, a *theory* of presidential campaign discourse, this issue must at least be approached.

Benoit, Blaney, and Pier have written a book that is a valuable read for the target audiences identified in the introductory paragraph to this review. The book is a well-presented case study with extensive data collected regarding political campaign discourse in the 1996 presidential campaign. While falling short of supporting the theory proposed by the authors, the work raises intriguing questions that suggest value to further study.

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Larson Consulting. *Smart Tournament Administrator* Version 02-05-01. Freeware.

In the mid-1980's, Dr. Gary Larson set out to debunk the notion that the process of matching preliminary debate rounds was "more art than science." Larson recalls anecdotally that many people scoffed at his insistence that a computer could match and tabulate debate rounds as reliably as the most experienced tournament administrators. Today, however, virtually every intercollegiate debate tournament, including the CEDA, NDT, and NPDA national tournaments, uses computerized matching and tabulation. A project that is now over 15 years old, Larson's Smart Tournament Administrator (STA) is an excellent software package for the full range of debate tournament data management chores. This review focuses on the most recent version (v2-05-01) which has successfully operated under the Windows95, Windows 98, Windows ME, Windows NT, and Windows 2000 environments.

STA is available as freeware, and can be downloaded from <ftp://ftp.wheaton.edu/pub/debate>. Downloads are available in both single install (single install.exe) and multiple floppy disk install versions.<sup>1</sup> The latter involves downloading both

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<sup>1</sup> File Transfer Protocol requires right clicking on the file name, choosing "Save file to" and selecting a destination drive.

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